

Samsung Galaxy M34 5G

Good bang for your buck

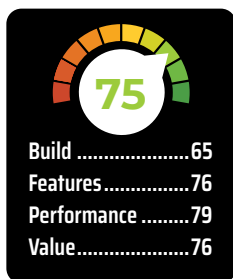
Samsung's 2023 portfolio of smartphones has been fascinating to review. The company is consciously attempting stylistically homogenize its various smartphone series – be it their budget offerings or their premium launches. The newly-launched Samsung Galaxy M34 5G is a prime example of that. The design language – of the rear panel, at least – is extremely reminiscent of the flagship S series. The Samsung Galaxy M34 5G is impressive. It features the tried and tested Exynos 1280 SoC, it houses a ludicrously large 6,000 mAh battery, and its primary camera produces some impressive results in daylight. But the overbearing question remains – how does the phone perform and is it worth your hard-earned money? I answer that and more in my detailed review of the Samsung Galaxy M34 5G.

BUILD AND DESIGN

As I mentioned before, the Samsung Galaxy M34 fits right into the 2023 portfolio of Samsung phones – you've got that recognisable, distinct look with the vertically-placed circular camera modules that sets it apart from most others in the market. However, while I appreciate the consistency, I still do not believe that this is the best design on a smartphone in its price range.

The rear panel of the Samsung Galaxy M34 is made of polycarbonate that looks very similar to glass but the surface is an absolute fingerprint and smudge magnet. We found it extremely tricky to keep the rear panel clean enough to take good product shots. The fingerprints accumulate within seconds of cleaning the device, which is aggravating. The camera modules look classy, just as they do on other Samsung devices we've reviewed

₹18,990



this year. The Samsung branding on the bottom is also nice and subtle.

The sides of the phone are made of plastic as well. The bottom houses the USB C port, 3.5 mm jack (yay!), and the sole Dolby Atmos-enabled speaker. The speaker is loud but doesn't

compare to the experience you get with stereo speakers. The right side houses the volume rockers and power button. The power button also doubles as a capacitive fingerprint sensor, which proved to be speedy and accurate. The left side has the SIM tray which can hold 2 nano SIMs, or 1 nano SIM and an SD card. We'll talk about the front of the device in the next section.

At 208 g, the phone is pretty hefty by 2023 standards. It is also 8.8 mm thick. Samsung has done a good job distributing the weight though and the phone is quite comfortable to hold. It is awfully slippery though, so we advise buying a protective case since Samsung doesn't provide one in the packaging.

DISPLAY

The Samsung Galaxy M34's aesthetic appeal takes a major fall when you look at the screen. The outdated waterdrop notch and chunky chin bezel make it look like a phone from the yesteryears – or at least ₹5-10K cheaper than it is. This is a shame because this shell houses a gorgeous 6.5-inch Super AMOLED FHD+ display with 120 Hz refresh rate support. There's no HDR support though, which is disappointing. The display is topped with Gorilla Glass 5 for protection against scratches and accidental drops.

The M34's screen packs a punch with vibrant colours and good viewing angles. The screen is quite bright as well, rated at 1000 nits of peak brightness. In my testing, the phone maxed out at 802 nits of brightness under sunlight with Auto Brightness turned on. So, screen legibility in sunlight is a non-issue. Content consumption on this device is good and the screen is capable of producing stunning and immersive visuals. But the immersion is marred by the massive teardrop notch.

PERFORMANCE

Housing the Exynos 1280 SoC, the Samsung Galaxy M34 5G is a speedy performer. This is a 5 nm chipset that comes with two Cortex-A78 cores clocked at 2.4 GHz and six Cortex-A55 cores clocked at 2 GHz. I found this chipset to provide a good mix of power and efficiency. My review unit came with 6 GB LPDDR4X RAM (+ 6 GB Virtual RAM) and 128 GB of onboard UFS 2.2 storage with the option to expand it via a microSD card.

The phone performed admirably well in benchmarks against competitors such as the iQOO Z7 and the OnePlus Nord CE 3 Lite. In AnTuTu, the Samsung Galaxy M34 flew past the OnePlus Nord CE 3 Lite's score and it even did slightly better than the iQOO Z7. The Galaxy M34 proved its mettle in the Geekbench as well – scoring considerably higher than both the iQOO Z7 and Nord CE 3 Lite but these phones beat it out in the Multi Core test, as you can see below. But it regained its lead in PCMark Work, meaning it will do a great job at productivity tasks such as